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MAHARASHTRA

Diversity in Unity

The going may not be smooth for the Congress and NCP as the 'sons of the soil' in Maharashtra unite to form a Third Front

By Malini Bhupta |

If there's one word that describes the Congress-led Democratic Front (DF) Government in Maharashtra, it's unputdownable. The party's stellar performance in the recent Lok Sabha elections has even stunned several Congress leaders in the state, which they attribute to the TINA (there is no alternative) factor and not their own performance.

The picture does not look rosy any more for the Congress and NCP. This is evident from Kalavati Bandurkar's decision to contest from Vidarbha for Swatantra Bharat Paksh. While this small party in Vidarbha may be unknown, Kalavati has become the poster-girl for India's marginalised, thanks to Rahul Gandhi's speech in Parliament.

While the Congress and NCP have been bickering over seats, a clutch of small parties have

come together to give the state's electorate a secular alternative. Hoping to counter the might and misrule of the ruling DF, an organised alternative has taken shape in the form of the RLD, comprising a ragtag conglomeration of 18 parties from across the state. Not only will the Dalit votes swing in favour of this Front, even local parties like the Swabhimani Shetkari Sangathan (sss) in western Maharashtra will eat into the



THE THIRD FRONT SEEKS TO CHALLENGE THE MIGHT OF THE LEADING PARTIES